

LIGHT ON A KINGDOM
OF WONDER



MOROCCO



Morocco by its trails

Authentic, inspiring, welcoming... Are you ready to succumb to Morocco's charms?

A land of light, but also a land of cultural and gastronomic riches, few destinations offer so many possibilities in a single stay. Discover the desert in the midst of the Sahara's dunes, go climbing in the Atlas mountains, recharge your batteries on beaches of fine golden sand, stroll through the streets of its ancestral medinas...

Morocco is an incomparable destination. You'll be touched by the Moroccan people's hospitality and the gentle pace of local life.

You'll also find an extraordinary variety of landscapes: deserts, mountains, beaches, forests, oases and green valleys... Morocco's nature is made for hikers, climbers, horse riders, and water-sports enthusiasts. Unforgettable treks and expeditions await in remarkable natural settings. Lace up your boots - it's time for an adventure!

Morocco at a glance



A change of scenery on every level. Whether you're a mountain enthusiast, want to lose yourself in the immensity of the desert or discover rich and diverse flora, Morocco will provide nature lovers with an experience fit for dreams. The country is overflowing with treasures to discover while hiking. Between the Mediterranean and the Sahara desert, the Atlas massif provides sports enthusiasts with an opportunity to reach for the skies as they climb to the top of the Toubkal, North Africa's highest peak. On the country's Atlantic coast, a region well known to board sports fans, the coastal trails linking Essaouira to Agadir will lead travellers to discover little fishing villages, wild coves and sandy beaches. In the province of Ifrane, visitors can make their way into a magnificent cedar forest abounding in streams and lakes, not to forget the wonders of the desert and its oases and palm groves, as in the Draa and Dades valleys. With nature outings suited to all tastes and fitness levels, trekking enthusiasts will get to know Morocco's many different facets while taking the time to immerse themselves in Moroccan culture and traditions.



Itinerary 1

Explore from above

Marrakesh – Ouarzazate – Dades – Tinghir

Set off to discover the Moroccan Atlas. Hike through spectacular landscapes, from the Dades Gorge to the Tamlalt cliffs. Pay a visit to the plantations in the green valley of Tinghir. And don't forget Ouarzazate, whose desert backdrops are a favourite of the film industry.



Itinerary 2

The Atlantic as a compass

Essaouira – Taghazout – Agadir

Coastal trails with the ocean as far as the eye can see. Explore the fishing villages between Essaouira and Agadir. Feel like a well-deserved break? Enjoy grilled fish on a sandy beach while admiring the surfers' prowess. To the south of Agadir, the Souss-Massa National Park will delight wildlife enthusiasts.



Itinerary 3

In discovery of the national parks

Fez – Beni Mellal – Marrakesh

Morocco has numerous national parks. In Ifrane's, visitors can hike through its forests, taking in waterways and caves along the way. The Khenifra National Park near Beni Mellal is well known to canoeing, kayaking and rafting enthusiasts. Also not to be missed: the Iminifri Bridge, a natural arch carved into the rock, not far from Demnate.

Morocco off the beaten track

Lovers of wide open spaces, thrills and hiking of all kinds, take note: Morocco, in all its diversity, is made for you. It’s next to impossible not to find what you’re looking for among the many outdoor activities on offer in enchanting settings. All you have to do is choose.

Whether you’re a seasoned mountaineer or a novice hiker in search of new experiences, there’s bound to be a Moroccan trail for you. The country is full of itineraries to follow, from the dunes of the Sahara to the snow-capped peaks of the Atlas Mountains. High-altitude enthusiasts can climb to the top of Toubkal, the highest mountain in North Africa. If you prefer trail running, you’ll be able to exercise in the midst of our green valleys and forests, less known to the country’s visitors but just as spectacular. Covering some 9 million hectares, they’re home to an extraordinarily rich biodiversity. These excursions can be enjoyed whether you’re walking, running, or even by bike.



The snow on the peaks of the Atlas mountains creates fairytale landscapes.



The country’s Atlantic coast has more than its fair share of hiking trails.



The Dades Gorge’s ochre-coloured rocks will captivate geology lovers.

The essentials

3 experiences not to be missed



1



2



3

(1) Climbing to the top of Toubkal : reaching North Africa’s highest peak has to be earned. A two- or three-day climb from the village of Imlil gives you a chance to admire the panorama from the top of the 4,167-metre Moroccan giant. But don’t worry, Toubkal can be scaled in stages, and you don’t have to go all the way to the top.

(2) Trekking between the Valley of the Roses and the gorges of M’Goun mountain: ochre-coloured mountains, lush green vegetation growing on the banks of the M’Goun Wadi, kasbah villages... This region of Morocco provides hikers with an unforgettable immersion in the very heart of authentic Amazigh culture.

(3) Discover the wild Atlantic coast: stretching for almost 3,500 kilometres, Morocco’s Atlantic coast is a must for wilderness enthusiasts. After departing from Essaouira, take the time to enjoy the coves, sandy beaches and fishing villages alongside the ocean. And why not go on horseback for a few kilometres?

The origins of...

Collective granaries and tazotas



Need a break from the day’s hiking? Real architectural treasures, the collective granaries (or igoudar) are mainly found in the Anti-Atlas and Souss regions. Composed of dozens of chambers, these fortified stone complexes were used by the Amazighs to store their harvests and safeguard their valuables (money, jewellery, clothes and so on). In times of crisis or danger, they could also be used to shelter communities and their animals. While the Aït Kine granary is one of the few still in operation, several others can be visited today, as can the

tazotas. Cylindrical in shape and built from limestone, these structures date from the first half of the 20th century and are found in the Doukkala region. They provided shelter from the heat for people and animals and were also used to store crops. A dazzling detour.

Morocco can also be explored by water. Perfect for thrill-seekers, you can go rafting or canoeing on the Ourika Wadi, near Marrakesh, or on the Ahansal in the High Atlas. You can also try your hand at paragliding or hang-gliding in the Atlas mountains or on the Atlantic coast. Animal lovers will also find what they're looking for. On the Atlantic coast, pony trekking trails take experienced riders on adventures between hills, beaches and palm groves. You can also ride a camel for a few hours. Once the indispensable companions of desert nomads, used in bygone days to carry goods, camels now travel in caravans, a unique way to combine an outing with culture. Another age-old tradition: the art of falconry. Workshops introduce travellers to these birds of prey used for hunting. Morocco can also be discovered through the prism of agriculture. With agritourism on the rise, you can immerse yourself in the country's rural areas by staying on a farm. No matter what kind of great outdoors you like, Morocco has everything on hand to delight you.



A must-do experience

Walk the footsteps of the dinosaurs

This treasure in the heart of Aït Bouguemez valley – nicknamed the "Happy Valley" – is ideal for a multi-day family excursion. Children can marvel at dinosaur footprints left on the slopes of Iggherm de Sidi Moussa hill, sure to leave them speechless! Meanwhile, adults can admire traditional adobe villages, legacies of a long Amazigh tradition, and enjoy friendly encounters with their inhabitants. The valley, which lies 1,800 metres above sea level, is also known for its terrace farming practices. Architecture, culture, nature and history: the Aït Bouguemez valley was awarded Unesco's "Global Geopark" label in 2014. And for total immersion in flora and fauna, visit the Geopark Museum in Azilal.

4,167 metres

The height of Mount Toukbal, Morocco's highest peak, which provides experienced hikers with spectacular views of the High Atlas range.



1. Whether you're a beginner or an expert, Morocco is bound to have an ideal hiking trail that'll transport you to other worlds.

2. Rafting is an excellent way of immersing yourself in the depths of Morocco's forests.
3. There's nothing better than a stream if you want to cool off during a trek... or spice it up a bit.

4. Tafraoute's painted rocks in the Almenn valley form a spectacular setting.

My very own Morocco

A meeting with mountain guide Hafida Hdoubane

For over 30 years, Hafida Hdoubane has been tirelessly exploring Morocco's mountains and valleys. The first woman in the Kingdom to become a mountain guide, she delights in introducing hikers to her country, its landscapes, people and art of living.

Please introduce yourself

My name's Hafida Hdoubane. I'm 56 and I was born in Marrakesh. I've been an official or accredited mountain guide since 1994.

How did you get into hiking?

I've always been drawn to the mountains and adventure. I found this desire to climb ever higher a bit strange. Even as a little girl, I loved sport. I watched the Olympics on TV, I went running... Then, while I was studying at the Tangier hotel school, I had the opportunity to go to Spain for an internship with some friends. We were supervising children who'd come to go climbing. That's when my passion was born. I realised that I could make a living thanks to the sports I loved so much. On my return to Morocco, I met a guide who invited me to try hiking in the mountains, which I knew nothing about. Things worked out bit by bit. I did internships, met new people, worked as a cook on mountain-bike tours, as a muleteer... And at last I was ready to take the mountain guide exam.

So you decided to make a career out of it. As a woman, was it difficult?

There were 400 candidates for the exam, including four women. I remember we had to cover 30 kilometres in less than 8 hours in order to pass. I succeeded. It wasn't easy at the time, but the competition pushed me to my limits. Either I'd crack, or tell myself I was just as capable of doing it as a man. It gave me strength. Over the course of my career, I've guided over 6,000 people. What do I enjoy most about my job? The calm, the encounters, the sharing and the pride of helping them discover the nature and beauty of our country.

Why is it important to be accompanied by a guide when you decide to go trekking in Morocco?

A guide will keep you safe. Mountains can be dangerous. They'll also share their knowledge of the landscapes they've visited and their inhabitants.

What equipment and clothing would you recommend taking with you on a trek in Morocco?

A waterproof jacket. Even if it's hot in Marrakesh, the weather can turn quickly in the Atlas Mountains. Hikers should also pack a first aid kit, a water bottle and, of course, a camera to take breathtaking photos.

Regarding food for this type of holiday, what do you recommend to your clients?

Food is very important on a trek. If you've got a mountain to climb or a long day's walking to do, make sure you refuel properly with plenty of variety tagines, soups, salads, pasta and so on. The hikers I guide eat Moroccan food. A cook who accompanies us prepares the meals on these treks.

When it comes to accommodation during a trek, what do you think is the best option to ensure an unforgettable holiday?

Whether you spend a night in a tent, an inn, a kasbah or a homestay, all options are good! They create unforgettable memories.

Three words to describe trekking in Morocco?

Discovery, encounters and beauty. The first for the adventure in the heart of our country, the second for the Amazigh people, who deserve to be better known. They've kept their authenticity and are happy to share their age-old traditions with visitors. The third is for the landscapes the country has to offer. Their diversity is one of our greatest assets.



What hikes in Morocco do you think are a must, depending on whether you're a beginner or expert?

For less experienced hikers, I recommend the M'Goun gorges and the Saghro massif, a sort of Moroccan Monument Valley. Desert roaming can also be a good option. More experienced hikers can venture up Mount M'Goun. It's 4,071 metres above sea level and still very wild. At the summit, you can admire the desert on one side and the valley on the other.



7,000 species



Sea, mountains, desert and forest: the diversity of Moroccan landscapes is enhanced by a rich and varied flora.



A must-do experience

Marvel at the wonders of the Souss Massa National Park

Created in 1991, Souss Massa National Park is located between Agadir and Tiznit, on Morocco's Atlantic coast. Covering 33,800 hectares, visitors can discover over 300 plant species as well as a wide variety of wildlife, including mongooses, gazelles, jackals, ostriches and addaxes (a species of antelope with a spotted nose). More than 20 species of reptiles have also been identified. Birdwatchers will also be delighted, as hundreds of species make their home in the area, including falcons, cormorants, gulls and herons. The National Park is a major site major site committed to the conservation of Saharan fauna, as well as a magnificent setting to explore on foot or on a safari.

By the way...

Morocco has astonishingly diverse landscapes. In addition to its dunes and vast expanses of sand, the Moroccan desert has plenty of surprises in store. Formed along waterways, green havens like oases and palm groves, such as those in the Draa and Dades valleys, have sprung up in the midst of desert landscapes. Date, olive, almond, palm, apricot and fig trees grow here, providing precious food for the whole country. A treat for taste buds and eyes alike. If you'd like to find out more, take a look at our "Light on a Land of Deserts" brochure.



Immersion

Living on the farm

If you'd like to immerse yourself fully in traditional Amazigh culture, agritourism is made for you. And why not go green? 250 kilometres east of Marrakesh, the M'Goun Massif is famous for its hiking trails and not-to-be-missed climbs, but the region is also ideal for another kind of tourism. It's home to magnificent villages where Amazigh tribes live, with agriculture and craftsmanship providing their livelihoods. Take Abachkou, on the slopes of Mount Anghomar –an ideal agri-tourism destination. Meet the locals and immerse yourself in rural life-producing cereal, honey, nuts, milk and butter, alongside livestock farming- and try your hand at traditional crafts with pottery and weaving workshops. An authentic experience, far off the beaten track, that can be enjoyed over one or more days, in a homestay or on a farm. It's a great way to promote the treasures of these rural areas while reconnecting with nature and making unforgettable encounters.

Good to know

Get a professional guide to accompany you on your hikes in the Moroccan countryside. Thanks to their knowledge of the mountains, itineraries, geology and flora and fauna, as well as the inhabitants' local traditions, you'll uncover the often hidden treasures of the country's lush landscapes. Travel with confidence and enjoy passing the time with these true ambassadors of their region.

Salam aleykoum

The essence of words السلام عليكم

In the Amazigh language (Tamazight), the word "Azul" is used to say **hello**. Just like "Salam", a word that means "peace" in Arabic, which can be used both as a polite greeting and friendly farewell during your Moroccan getaway.



Memories, memories

3 little things to slip into your suitcase...

- Bellogs:** made from wood and leather and decorated with Amazigh motifs, they can be used to fan fires or decorate your home.
- A wool jacket:** colours, motifs... there's something for everyone.
- A raffia bottle cover:** to dress decoration lovers' tables and keep water cold.

A moroccan "day in the life"



10 am After enjoying Moroccan-style pancakes for breakfast, you don your hiking boots.



1 pm Carrots, courgettes, peppers, chickpeas, spices... You savour the flavours of a vegetarian tagine.



4 pm Time to take a break in the shade of the almond trees, in bloom at the end of winter, and enjoy a glass of tea.



6 pm Dream away to the rhythm of Moroccan music groups.



7 pm Enjoy a meal of grilled beef, lamb, chicken or fish.



9 pm Get up high to admire the sunset, which adorns the landscape with its most beautiful colours every

Spotlight on...



OCEAN WAVES



CRAFTS



BEACH AND SUN



CULTURE



GASTRONOMY



BUSINESS TRIP



OFF THE TRACKS HOSTING



CITY BREAKS



SUSTAINABILITY



DESERT AND OASES



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